

Case Study - UPI/ Online Payment Fraud

With the rapid growth of digital payments, UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud has become a common cybercrime, especially among college students and young adults. It usually takes advantage of people's trust and lack of awareness about how digital transactions actually work.

A typical case begins when a student posts an item for sale online or expects a payment from someone. The fraudster contacts them pretending to be a genuine buyer or service provider. After gaining their trust through polite conversation, the scammer sends a QR code or a payment request, claiming that it is required to "receive" money. In reality, scanning the code or approving the request results in money being debited from the victim's account. In some situations, the victim is also asked to share an OTP or UPI PIN, which further compromises their account security.

Students, first-time users of digital payments, and elderly individuals are the most common targets because they may not fully understand these tactics or may act quickly without verifying the situation. The consequences can include financial loss, anxiety, and reduced confidence in online payment systems. In many cases, recovering the lost money is difficult if action is not taken immediately.

This case highlights the importance of awareness. Users should always remember that receiving money never requires entering a PIN or approving a payment request, and any suspicious activity should be carefully verified.

Stay Safe Online - Checklist for College Students

Use strong, unique passwords

Create passwords with a mix of letters, numbers, and symbols. Avoid using the same password for multiple accounts.

Enable Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)

Turn on 2FA for apps like email, banking, and social media to add an extra layer of security.

Be cautious of phishing links

Don't click on suspicious links sent via SMS, email, or WhatsApp—even if they look official.

Verify UPI requests before approving

Always check the sender's name and purpose before approving any payment request on apps like Google Pay or PhonePe.

Never share UPI PIN or OTP

No bank or official will ever ask for your PIN or OTP. Sharing it can lead to instant financial loss.

Avoid public Wi-Fi for sensitive transactions

Do not log into banking or payment apps on public networks (like cafés or college Wi-Fi).

Keep your apps and devices updated

Regular updates fix security bugs and protect you from malware and hacking attempts.

Limit personal information online

Avoid sharing your phone number, address, college ID, or daily routine publicly on social media.

Download apps only from trusted sources

Install apps only from official stores (Play Store/App Store) and check reviews before downloading.

Log out from shared devices

Always log out of accounts when using library or cyber café computers.

If you face cybercrime

Report immediately on the National Cyber Crime Portal

cybercrime.gov.in

Call Helpline: 1930 (especially for financial fraud)